

Pook's Tangled Paths

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, an old, bright salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is full of ideas, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.*

Before you begin

It is nearly time for the May fair. But the winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove have gone all tangled. Soft ribbons of mist loop them over and round, and now the village folk cannot find their way to the fair.

Who did this? Pook the Puca, a playful faerie who can change his shape. He did not mean any harm. He only wanted a game.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver calls you to the Roundhouse. "You two have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you go and untangle the paths, and win Pook over with a friendly word?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red wool, a honey oatcake, and a sprig of oak for luck. Then she smiles. "Here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Kindness?*

Stop 1 The Tangled Grove

You step into the grove. The paths loop and twist and double back on themselves. You walk and walk, and somehow you keep coming back to the same old oak tree.

It would be easy to get lost in here for ever.

★ *What could you do? You have a ball of red wool. Could you tie one end at the start and follow it as you go? Then you can always find your way back.*

When you tie the red wool at the start and unspool it behind you, you never lose your way. The grove cannot tangle a hero with a thread. Soon you find the path that leads deeper in.

Stop 2 Pook's Three Doors

The path opens into a clearing. There, Pook has grown three mossy doors out of oak branches, side by side. Only one door leads on. The others loop you straight back.

Pook pops up, a little furry shape with bright eyes, and gives you three teasing clues:

★ *"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."*



Which door is the true one? Could you read his clues again, slowly? Could you ask him for a hint?

When you choose the right-hand door, it swings open with a happy creak. Pook giggles and somersaults away into the leaves. You step on through.

Stop 3 Winning Pook Over

Deeper in the grove you find Pook again, sitting on a toadstool. He has stopped laughing now. He hugs his knees and looks at his feet.

He made the whole grove into a game, and now he feels a little bit sorry. He did not think the village folk would be sad.



This is not a fight. What kind thing could you do? You have a honey oatcake to share. You could sit beside him. You could tell him the fair has room for him too. What do you try?

When you are kind to him and share the honey oatcake, Pook's eyes go warm and bright. "You are not cross with me?" he whispers. "Then I will set it all right."

The Paths Run True

Pook hops up and claps his furry paws. All across the grove, the ribbons of mist unwind and float away. The winding paths run straight and true again.

And Pook does not vanish this time. He skips along beside you, leading the way, proud to help at last. Down in the village, the folk cheer as the paths open, and the May fair begins with music and dancing.

High above the green isles, Danu the Kind looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were brave, you were kind, and you were full of ideas. Well done, heroes.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale: the only "foe" is a lonely faerie who simply wants a friend, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Roundhouse.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red wool, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a leaf or twig for the sprig of oak. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In this grove, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze through the oaks, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

Pook the Puca is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a playful faerie who made a game of the paths and then felt sorry for the trouble it caused. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him: sharing the honey oatcake, sitting beside him, telling him there is a place for him at the fair. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. Befriended, Pook gladly untangles every path himself. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Tangled Grove (Easy)

The challenge. The winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove loop and double back, and the players keep arriving at the same old oak. They must find a way through without getting hopelessly lost.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination and Spatial moment. The good, kind move is to use the **ball of red wool**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong loop twice. Marking each turning, or following the thread back to try a new path, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, let the red wool tug gently towards the true path, or have a friendly robin hop ahead from branch to branch. Getting through with a little help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: Pook's Three Doors (Normal)

The challenge. Pook has grown three mossy archway doors of oak branches. Only one leads onward; the other two loop the players back. They must read his playful clues and choose the true door.

The clues. Read them aloud: *"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."* The **right-hand door** is the way on: the left clue says plainly that it sends you back, the middle clue admits it tells fibs, and the right clue is the only one that calls itself true.

Intended solution. This is a Logic and Observation moment. Let the children talk the clues through together and listen for the door that says it is true while the others give themselves away. A thoughtful guess is welcome too.

Fallback. If they are stuck, read the clues again slowly, one door at a time, or let Pook lean in and whisper, "Listen to which door tells the truth." A door chosen bravely still creaks open onto the right path.

Stop 3: Winning Pook Over (Normal, then no roll)

The challenge. The players find Pook the Puca hunched on a toadstool, no longer laughing. He looks small and sorry. The children may wonder how to make things right.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Pook is simply a little ashamed and unsure how to say sorry. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey oatcake**, sitting down beside him, telling him there is room for him at the May fair, saying that everyone makes a muddle sometimes. When the children are kind, Pook brightens and promises to set every path right himself.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to scold him, have Pook sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you cross with me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players offer any friendly gesture at all, he hops up and undoes the whole tangle.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When Pook claps his paws, the ribbons of mist unwind, the paths of the grove run straight and true, and Pook skips along to lead the heroes out himself.

The May fair goes ahead in a swirl of music and dancing, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from above the green isles. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.